ATHENS, GREECE

National Gallery — Alexandros Soutsos Museum: Masterpieces

Twenty works that range from children's music to the public memory of history.



A concert in a bright room and a desperate sortie from a besieged town make very different claims on attention. Iakovidis organises children around playing and listening. Vryzakis places earthly fighting beneath a heavenly assembly, making clear that his subject is also an act of commemoration. Both group bodies, but neither can be understood from the grouping alone.

This selection moves between observation, devotion and remembrance. Landscape studies and portraits offer another pace beside the historical scenes. The changes are useful: they prevent “Greek painting” from becoming one uniform manner, and make it easier to distinguish a depicted event from the form in which a later artist asks it to be remembered.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/national-gallery-greece

The selection · 20

1. Children's Concert
   Georgios Iakovidis · 1900
2. The Straw Hat
   Nikolaos Lytras · 1925
3. The Betrothal of the Children
   Nikolaos Gyzis · 1877
4. The Sortie of Messolonghi
   Theodoros Vryzakis · 1853
5. Behold the Bridegroom Arriving
   Nikolaos Gyzis · 1899–1900
6. The Apotheosis of Athanasios Diakos
   Konstantinos Parthenis · 1933
7. Annunciation
   Konstantinos Parthenis · 1910 - 1911
8. Landscape from Delphi
   Spyros Papaloukas · 1945
9. Anchored Boats
   Konstantinos Volanakis · c. 1895
10. The Entombment of Christ
    El Greco · c. 1568-1570
11. Adoration of the Shepherds
    Stephanos Tzangarolas · 1688–1700
12. Assumption of Mary
    Nikolaos Doxaras · 1725–1775
13. Ayia Anna, Chalkida
    Theophilos (Chatzimichael) · 1927
14. The Beautiful Adriana of Athens
    Theophilos (Chatzimichael) · 1930
15. Aswan
    Konstantinos Maleas · 1924
16. Actress
    George Bouzianis · 1954
17. Female Dancers
    George Bouzianis · 1936
18. Messolonghi Lagoon
    Sofia Laskaridou · 1905
19. Boy Reading
    Thaleia Flora-Karavia · c. 1906
20. Portrait of Pantelis Prevelakis
    Fotis Kontoglou · c. 1938 - 1939

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Children's Concert

Georgios Iakovidis

1900 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery — Alexandros Soutsos Museum



Georgios Jakobides. Children's Concert. Image credit: Georgios Jakobides. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

One child lacks a proper instrument and blows into a red watering bucket. That improvised contribution makes the gathering more particular than a general image of childhood merriment. Iakovidis distributes playing and listening across different ages, while light entering from two directions helps connect the group. The warm room accommodates distinct gestures rather than one synchronised performance.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Π.475

02 / 20

The Straw Hat

Nikolaos Lytras

1925 · National Gallery — Alexandros Soutsos Museum



Nikolaos Lytras. The Straw Hat. Image credit: Nikolaos Lytras. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The hat shades the face while becoming the portrait's brightest organising shape. Warm ground and buildings surround cooler clothing, giving sunlight a presence through large areas of colour. Nikolaos Lytras does not blend away every mark to describe the sitter. The contrast between the yellow brim and blue-grey figure establishes much of the picture's structure.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Π.492

03 / 20

The Betrothal of the Children

Nikolaos Gyzis

1877 · National Gallery — Alexandros Soutsos Museum



Nikolaos Gyzis. The Betrothal of the Children. Image credit: Nikolaos Gyzis. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The children are conspicuously small within an adult ceremonial arrangement. Seated figures and objects make their formal role visible without making them physically equal participants. Gyzis turns that disparity into the scene's central relation. Costume provides historical information, but scale reveals something else: a social practice is being organised around bodies too small to command the room.

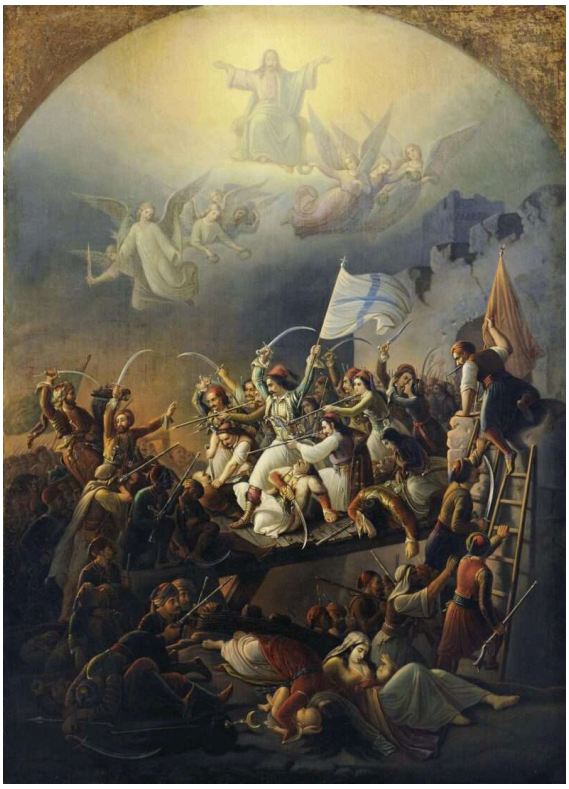
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Π.110

04 / 20

The Sortie of Messolonghi

Theodoros Vryzakis

1853 · National Gallery — Alexandros Soutsos Museum



Theodoros Vryzakis; Wikimedia Commons; Description of the painting in the National Gallery's website (http://www.nationalgallery.gr/). Inv. no: Π.5446. Source frame preserved; proportionally resized and JPEG compressed. · Public domain

The fighting below and the radiant heavenly gathering above belong to different orders of evidence. Vryzakis commemorates the 1826 sortie by placing the fighters within a religious account of sacrifice. The painting should therefore be read as a later construction of remembrance, not a neutral eyewitness view. Its divided heights explain that purpose as clearly as the crowded battle.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

Behold the Bridegroom Arriving

Nikolaos Gyzis

1899–1900 · National Gallery — Alexandros Soutsos Museum



Nikolaos Gyzis. Behold the Bridegroom Arriving. Image credit: Nikolaos Gyzis. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The glowing arch overwhelms the small pale figures before it. Details become harder to separate as they approach the radiance, making anticipated arrival a question of visibility. Gyzis gives the sacred subject a vast setting without furnishing a fully describable earthly place. Scale and obscured boundaries carry more weight than a clearly narrated sequence of actions.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Π.641

06 / 20

The Apotheosis of Athanasios Diakos

Konstantinos Parthenis

1933 · National Gallery — Alexandros Soutsos Museum



Konstantinos Parthenis. The Apotheosis of Athanasios Diakos. Image: WikiArt. Copyright protected (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Copyright protected (WikiArt label)

Lightly outlined bodies and architecture occupy an invented ceremonial space. Parthenis's reduced modelling keeps the historical subject at a distance from ordinary physical description. The painting presents commemoration through allegory: the pale elongated figures are participants in an ideal order rather than witnesses whose positions could be checked against an account of the event.

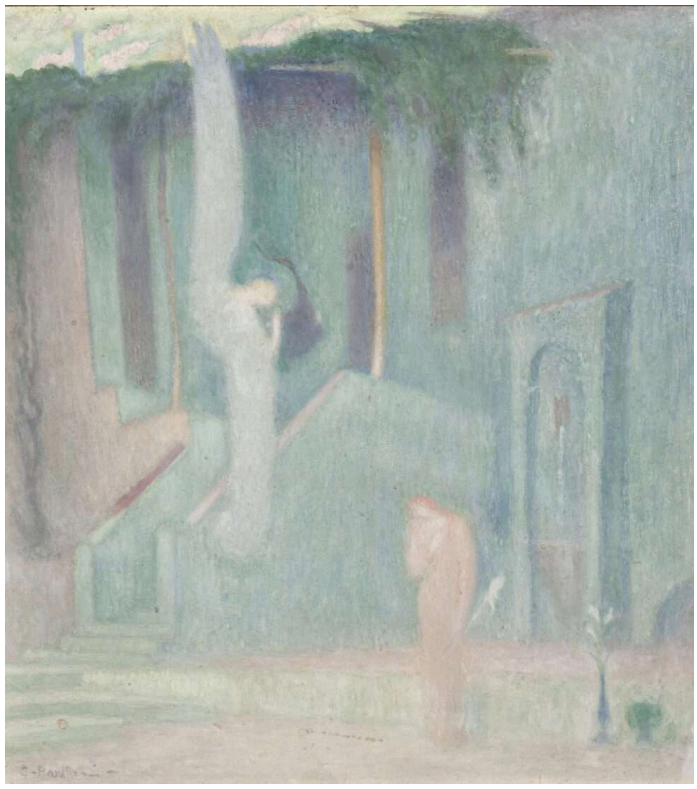
Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

Annunciation

Konstantinos Parthenis

1910 - 1911 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery — Alexandros Soutsos Museum



Konstantinos Parthenis; National Gallery – Alexandros Soutsos Museum; Inv. Number Π.6498. Source frame preserved; proportionally resized and JPEG compressed. · Source copyright retained; no reuse licence verified

The encounter is lightly stated within pale architecture and tall green forms. Parthenis uses intervals between the figures where another painter might supply dense furnishings or descriptive costume. A small pink area acquires importance because the rest is so restrained. The sacred subject remains recognisable close to the point at which its material setting begins to recede.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Π.6498

08 / 20

Landscape from Delphi

Spyros Papaloukas

1945 · Oil on canvas mounted on pasteboard · National Gallery — Alexandros Soutsos Museum



Spyros Papaloukas. Landscape from Delphi. Image: WikiArt. Copyright protected (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Copyright protected (WikiArt label)

Short blue and ochre marks break the pale slopes beneath the darker ridge. Papaloukas gives the terrain structure without concealing the separate strokes that construct it. A viewer can follow the ground into distance or attend to local changes of direction. The landscape's coherence survives without continuous smooth shading between every surface.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Π.4056

09 / 20

Anchored Boats

Konstantinos Volanakis

c. 1895 · National Gallery — Alexandros Soutsos Museum



Konstantinos Volanakis. Anchored boats. Image credit: Konstantinos Volanakis. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The fleet is at rest, but the scene is not empty. Differences of vessel size and the near boat measure the broad pale water beneath the extensive sky. Volanakis allows softened reflections to loosen the boats' lower boundaries. Their anchored condition gives the space a restrained occupancy rather than turning stillness into absence.

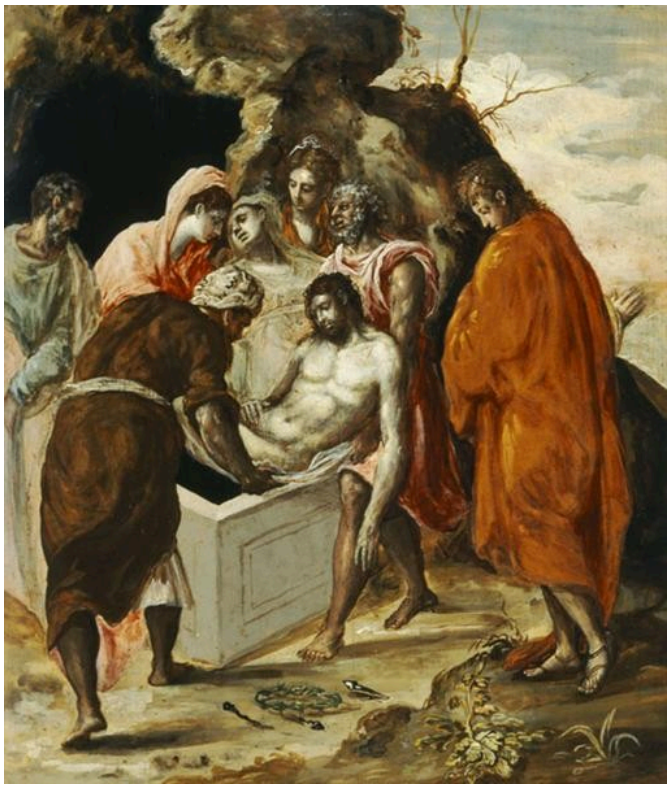
Object source · Open artwork

10 / 20

The Entombment of Christ

El Greco

c. 1568-1570 · Oil and tempera on panel · National Gallery — Alexandros Soutsos Museum



El Greco. The Entombment of Christ. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Interlocked arms make the dead body's weight a shared responsibility. El Greco compresses the carrying figures around the pale form beside the tomb, allowing grief to appear through practical support as well as gesture. The bright robes distinguish participants inside that pressure. Before each person is named, the difficulty of handling the body is already intelligible.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Π.9979

11 / 20

Adoration of the Shepherds

Stephanos Tzangarolas

1688–1700 · National Gallery — Alexandros Soutsos Museum



Stephanos Tzangarolas. Adoration of the Shepherds (Tzangarolas). Image credit: Stephanos Tzangarolas. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The close gathering around the infant occupies one part of a larger sacred arrangement. Gold connects earthly and heavenly levels without requiring them to share a single continuous viewpoint. Tzangarolas preserves the narrative encounter inside the image's devotional order. Moving between registers changes scale and kind of attention rather than simply moving farther into a room.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Π.147

12 / 20

Assumption of Mary

Nikolaos Doxaras

1725–1775 · National Gallery — Alexandros Soutsos Museum



Nikolaos Doxaras; Wikimedia Commons; Own work Official Website; photograph: Tzim78 (https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/User:Tzim78); CC BY-SA 4.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0). Source frame preserved; proportionally resized and JPEG compressed. · CC BY-SA 4.0

The witnesses' raised gestures connect the open tomb below to Mary's ascent above. Nikolaos Doxaras gives upward attention a bodily form, allowing earthly architecture and cloud to belong to one composition. The two zones need not have identical solidity. The figures bridge their difference through the direction of looking and movement.

Object source · Open artwork

13 / 20

Ayia Anna, Chalkida

Theophilos (Chatzimichael)

1927 · Oil on pasteboard · National Gallery — Alexandros Soutsos Museum



Theophilos (Chatzimichael); National Gallery – Alexandros Soutsos Museum; Inv. Number Π.6830. Source frame preserved; proportionally resized and JPEG compressed. · Source copyright retained; no reuse licence verified

People, animals and buildings remain individually readable across a densely occupied place. Theophilos allows uneven proportions to preserve useful particulars instead of submitting every detail to one distant viewpoint. The result rewards moving from activity to activity. Its account of place lies in accumulation, with several scales of attention allowed to coexist.

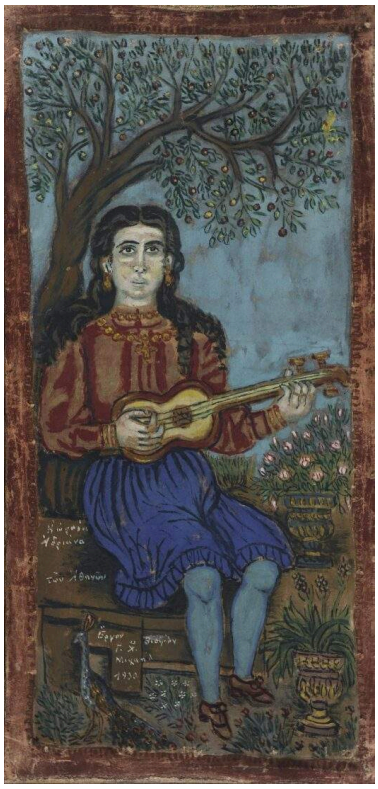
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Π.6830

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The Beautiful Adriana of Athens

Theophilos (Chatzimichael)

1930 · Thinned oil (?) on canvas · National Gallery — Alexandros Soutsos Museum



Theophilos (Chatzimichael); National Gallery – Alexandros Soutsos Museum; Inv. Number Π.6829. Source frame preserved; proportionally resized and JPEG compressed. · Source copyright retained; no reuse licence verified

The seated figure looks outward while holding her instrument, surrounded by clearly separated patterns and vegetation. Theophilos gives the named subject a frontal, emblem-like presence without abandoning the material signs of clothing and music. The narrow field holds these details close together. Recognition depends on their clarity more than on subtle modelling of depth.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Π.6829

15 / 20

Aswan

Konstantinos Maleas

1924 · Oil and pencil on pasteboard · National Gallery — Alexandros Soutsos Museum



Konstantinos Maleas. Aswan. Image credit: Konstantinos Maleas; Source credit: https://www.nationalgallery.gr/en/all-collections/collection/collections/aswan-2.html. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

Low structures and small figures establish a human measure beside broad water. Maleas separates the view into ochre and blue areas rather than filling every distance with descriptive detail. The buildings remain modest within the larger setting. Their presence makes the river inhabited without allowing a single foreground incident to dominate its extent.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: K.1232

16 / 20

Actress

George Bouzianis

1954 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery — Alexandros Soutsos Museum



George Bouzianis. Actress. WikiArt source label: George Bouzianis Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/george-bouzianis/actress-1954 · George Bouzianis Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

Warm clothing distinguishes the woman from dark blue strokes that press close around her. Bouzianis permits the paint to disturb an otherwise readable figure, leaving edges and proportions unsettled. The title identifies a role but does not explain the sitter's inner state. The visible drama belongs first to the difficulty of maintaining a stable bodily outline.

Object source · Open artwork

17 / 20

Female Dancers

George Bouzianis

1936 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery — Alexandros Soutsos Museum



George Bouzianis. Female Dancers. WikiArt source label: George Bouzianis Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/george-bouzianis/female-dancers-1936 · George Bouzianis Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

Loose contours prevent arms and bent legs from settling into immobile shapes. Bouzianis gives the two figures activity partly through that unfinished relation between body and surrounding darkness. Abbreviated faces leave gesture with more work to do. Movement is conveyed through the instability of the painted boundary as well as the pose it suggests.

Object source · Open artwork

18 / 20

Messolonghi Lagoon

Sofia Laskaridou

1905 · Oil on cardboard · National Gallery — Alexandros Soutsos Museum



Sofia Laskaridou; National Gallery – Alexandros Soutsos Museum; Inv. Number Π.3943. Source frame preserved; proportionally resized and JPEG compressed. · Source copyright retained; no reuse licence verified

No large foreground object is needed to establish the lagoon's breadth. Laskaridou separates water, distant land and atmosphere through modest changes within a pale range. Scattered reflections keep the nearest water active without breaking the extended view. The painting asks for attention to small tonal distinctions rather than a search for a single commanding feature.

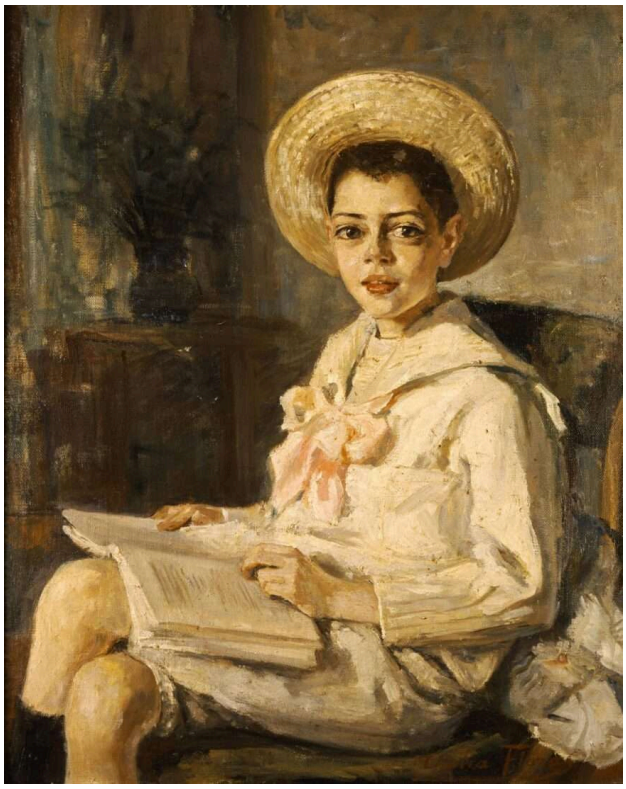
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Π.3943

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Boy Reading

Thaleia Flora-Karavia

c. 1906 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery — Alexandros Soutsos Museum



Thaleia Flora-Karavia; National Gallery – Alexandros Soutsos Museum; Inv. Number Π.4166. Source frame preserved; proportionally resized and JPEG compressed. · Source copyright retained; no reuse licence verified

The open book identifies an activity that the turned head has momentarily interrupted. Flora-Karavia makes that pause legible without removing the reading from the scene. The boy's attention now extends beyond the pages, but its new object remains unspecified. A familiar action can be suspended without the painting needing to invent an entire surrounding incident.

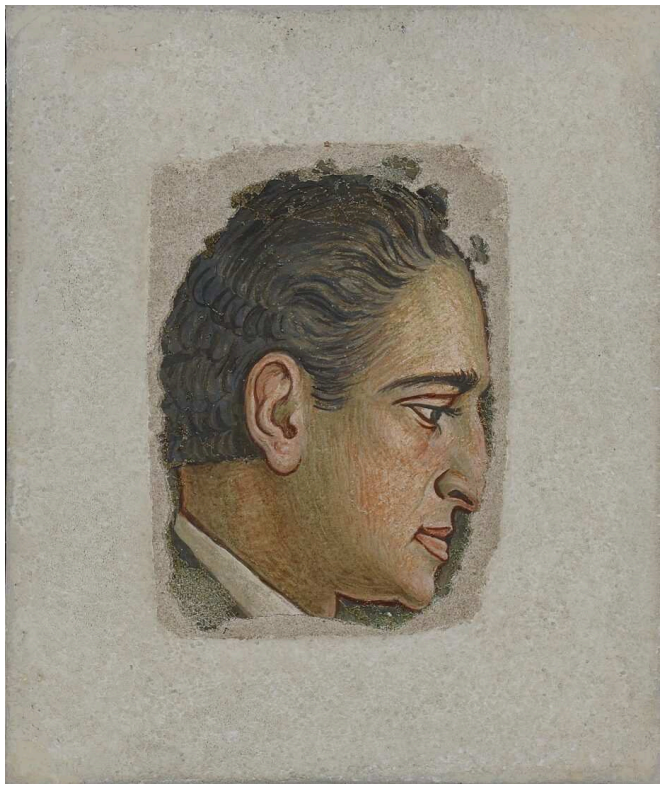
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Π.4166

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Portrait of Pantelis Prevelakis

Fotis Kontoglou

c. 1938 - 1939 · Egg tempera fresco · National Gallery — Alexandros Soutsos Museum



Fotis Kontoglou; National Gallery – Alexandros Soutsos Museum; Inv. Number Π.8111. Source frame preserved; proportionally resized and JPEG compressed. · Source copyright retained; no reuse licence verified

The shoulders are lightly stated, leaving the profile, dark hair and strongly drawn eye to carry the likeness. Kontoglou concentrates on the relation between contour and facial structure against a pale ground. The portrait's economy is selective rather than careless: some parts remain abbreviated so that a few decisive lines can receive sustained attention.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Π.8111

Distinguish the kinds of evidence

Compare the historical commemorations with a portrait or landscape: each offers different grounds for interpretation. Do not treat an allegorical image as a literal report. For practical planning, consult the gallery's current display information rather than assuming every collection work is available together.

Further reading

Four Centuries of Greek Painting

National Gallery–Alexandros Soutzos Museum; edited by Olga Mentzafou-Polyzou (3rd edition, 2013) · Free English PDF from the National Gallery. Historical catalogue; its floor plans and display information are not current.

The gallery’s illustrated catalogue supplies longer historical context for many of these artists, from post-Byzantine painting to modern Greek art. It is available in English as a full PDF. Use it for the collection and essays, not present-day display locations.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12
